

Kai Gu

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🕒 Updated: September 4, 2026

Education

Bocconi University
PhD in Marketing

Milan, Italy
2026 – Present

Bocconi University
MSc in Data Science

Milan, Italy
2024 – 2026

Zhejiang University
BEcon in Economics

Hangzhou, China
2020 – 2024

Research Interests

Substantive: Economics of AI, Economics of Digitization & Platforms, Media Economics

Methodological: Causal Inference, Computational Social Sciences, Multimodal Data

Working Papers

Answering Without Referring: How AI Search Rewrites the Web's Economic Bargain

Qiaoni Shi, Kai Zhu, and Kai Gu

Search engines have long allocated attention on the web by routing users from queries to websites. AI search changes this arrangement because information needs can be resolved inside the intermediary. Using URL-level Comscore U.S. desktop clickstream, we compare ChatGPT and Google information-seeking occasions and exploit ChatGPT Search access expansions to estimate traditional search displacement. ChatGPT produces outbound clicks in only 5.2% of conversation sessions, far below Google's referral ratio. The remaining clicks are not a scaled-down Google stream: they skew toward specialized destinations and away from ad-supported sites. Wider access cuts search use by 9.4%, with search-referral losses largest for informational categories. Our findings identify a central economic shift in digital intermediation: AI search might satisfy information needs inside the intermediary while weakening the referral bargain that has linked search, traffic, and content production on the open web.

Governing AI Content Tools: The Efficiency–Diversity Trade-off in Platform Knowledge Ecosystems

Kai Zhu, Kai Gu, and Lorenzo Lupo

Conference Presentations

12th CEPR Text-as-Data Workshop (Online)

September 2026

ISMS Marketing Science Conference, Lisbon, Portugal

June 2026

Bocconi Marketing Research Camp

May 2026

13th Wiki Workshop (Online)

March 2026

Skills

Languages: English, Mandarin

Programming: R, Python, L^AT_EX, Markdown